

THE CLAUDE BEAST | EPISODE 03

Claude Skills

Teaching AI agents repeatable workflows
through markdown instruction templates

February 2026 | Agentic Development Series

Skills are markdown workflow templates that teach Claude how to complete tasks repeatably

The Core Concept

- A folder with a SKILL.md file containing YAML frontmatter + markdown instructions
- Operates through prompt expansion -- modifies how Claude processes requests
- Works across Claude.ai, Claude Code, and the API identically
- **No executable code required** — pure natural language instructions

MCP + Skills Analogy

MCP provides the professional kitchen:
access to tools, ingredients, and equipment.

Skills provide the recipes:
step-by-step instructions on how to create
something valuable.

Teach Claude once, benefit every time.
No more re-explaining preferences per session.

Progressive disclosure minimizes token usage while maintaining specialized expertise



Four paths from discovery to working skill, each suited to different use cases



Manual Creation Quick experiments

```
mkdir -p .claude/skills/my-skill
```

Create SKILL.md directly in your
project or home directory



Vercel add-skill CLI Multi-agent teams

```
npx add-skill vercel-labs/agent-skills
```

Cross-agent installer supporting
6+ AI coding tools



Plugin Marketplace Curated &
versioned

```
/plugin install superpowers@marketplace
```

Native Claude Code discovery,
install, and update system



Claude.ai Upload Non-CLI users

```
Settings > Capabilities > Skills
```

Upload zipped skill folders
via the web interface

The Agent Skills open standard has been adopted by 26+ platforms -- including direct competitors

Standard Highlights

- **Minimal spec** — readable in a few minutes
- A directory with SKILL.md is the only requirement
- YAML frontmatter: name + description (required)
- Progressive disclosure built into the spec
- Validation: `skills-ref validate ./my-skill`

Platform Adoption (26+)

Anthropic	Claude, Claude Code, Claude API
OpenAI	Codex
Google	Gemini CLI
Microsoft	GitHub Copilot, VS Code
Cursor	Cursor IDE
Others	Roo Code, Amp, Goose, Mistral AI, Databricks, and more

Superpowers transforms Claude from ad-hoc code generator into a disciplined engineering partner

59,873

GitHub Stars

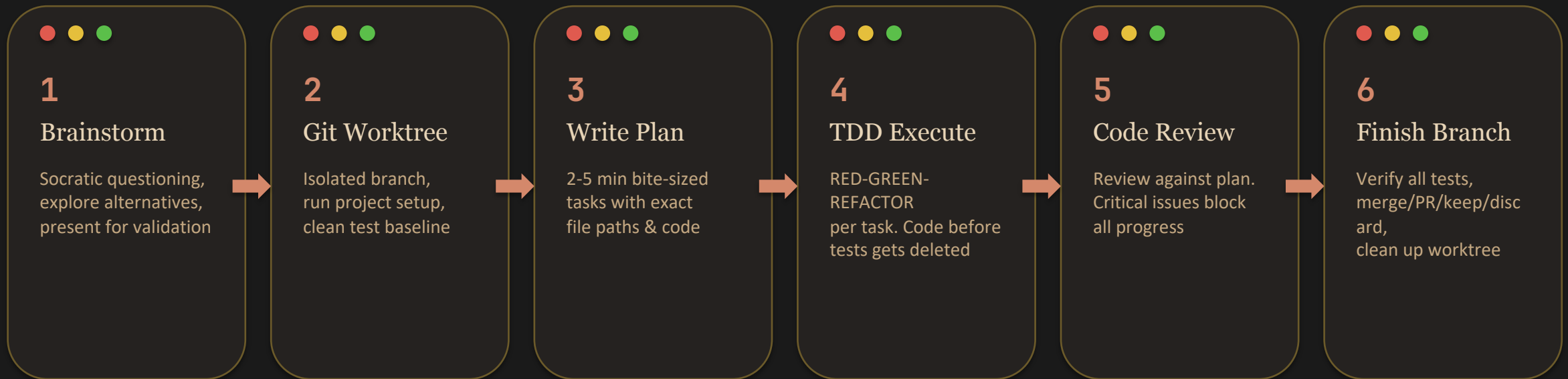
obra/superp

by Jesse Vincent

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Composable Skills

owers



"Mandatory workflows, not suggestions" -- Skills trigger automatically. The agent works autonomously for hours.

Official and community skills solve real problems from AI design slop to React performance



Frontend Design

Anthropic

Combats generic 'AI slop' aesthetics.
Guides bold design choices: brutalist, maximalist, retro-futuristic, luxury.

~42 lines of instructions



React Best Practices

Vercel Labs

57 rules across 8 categories of React & Next.js optimization, ranked by impact. 10+ years of knowledge encoded.

Cross-agent compatible



Document Skills

Anthropic

PDF, DOCX, PPTX, XLSX creation.
Powers Claude's native document generation capabilities.

Built-in to Claude



Skill Creator

Anthropic

Meta-skill: interactive guide for building new skills. From idea to tested skill in 15-30 minutes.

Bootstrap new skills

Building a custom skill takes 15-30 minutes and requires only a folder and a markdown file

Creation Process

- Identify 2-3 concrete use cases
- Choose category: Document Creation, Workflow Automation, or MCP Enhancement
- Create directory + SKILL.md with YAML frontmatter and instructions
- Test triggering on obvious and paraphrased requests
- Iterate on under/over-triggering signals

Best Practices

- **SKILL.md under 500 lines** — move detailed reference to separate files
- Description is the most important field (include WHAT + WHEN to use it)
- Context window is a public good -- your skill shares it with everything
- Be specific and actionable; avoid vague language in instructions
- Test with 10-20 queries; track the auto-triggering rate

Success: 90% auto-trigger rate | Fewer tool calls | Consistent results across sessions

A maturing marketplace ecosystem enables discovery, distribution, and community contribution

Key Marketplaces

Anthropic Official	<code>/plugin marketplace add anthropics/skills</code>	Document skills, examples
Claude Code Plugins	<code>/plugin marketplace add anthropics/claude-code</code>	Frontend design
Superpowers	<code>/plugin marketplace add obra/superpowers-...</code>	Full dev workflow
Vercel Agent Skills	<code>npx add-skill vercel-labs/agent-skills</code>	React best practices +

Community Discovery Platforms



skills.sh

Vercel's web-based
skills directory



playbooks.com

Skills browser
and installer



claude-plugins.dev

Community skills
discovery



mcpservers.org

Skills listing
and search

Skills are the knowledge layer that transforms AI agents

1. Knowledge Layer -- MCP gives tools. Skills teach how to use them. Together they enable complex autonomous workflows.

2. Open Standard -- 26+ platforms including competitors have adopted Agent Skills. Write once, run everywhere.

3. Progressive Disclosure -- Three-level loading preserves

the context window while maintaining specialized expertise on demand.

4. Enforced Discipline -- Mandatory workflows, not suggestions.

Brainstorm, plan, TDD, review -- automatically, every time.

Start today: `mkdir -p .claude/skills/my-first-skill && create SKILL.md` | Build & test in 15-30 minutes